

Aquifer Open Study Notes

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This resource has been adapted into multiple languages, including English, Tok Pisin, Arabic (عربي), French (Français), Hindi (हिंदी), Indonesian (Bahasa Indonesia), Portuguese (Português), Russian (Русский), Spanish (Español), Swahili (Kiswahili), and Simplified Chinese (简体中文).

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1 John 1:1

We proclaim to you the one who existed from the beginning: That is, from before time began, eternally ([John 8:58](#)). When Jesus came in the flesh ([John 1:14](#)), the apostles saw him . . . and touched him. This affirmation that they actually touched the Word of life is important because Gnosticism and Docetism (early Christian heresies) denied that Christ was truly a human being (see [1 Jn 4:2-3](#)). Jesus, the Son of God, is the personal expression of the invisible God, and the giver of eternal life ([John 1:1-4](#)).

1 John 1:1-4

This poetic prologue reflects the message of the prologue to John's Gospel ([John 1:1-18](#)). • The we that occurs throughout the prologue refers to John and the other apostles, and perhaps to other Christians who had seen and touched Jesus Christ. The apostles were among the eyewitnesses of Jesus and had personal fellowship with God through him. John, representing the apostles, now invites readers to join in that fellowship.

1 John 1:2

life itself (Greek *zōē*): Throughout the New Testament, this word is used to designate the eternal life of God (e.g., [Eph 4:18](#)). This life resides in Christ, and he makes it available to all who believe in him. • This one . . . was revealed to us: Jesus, the Christ, was known to his apostles as a human being during his earthly ministry.

1 John 1:3

what we . . . have actually seen: The Word of life had, as a man, revealed God to the apostles. • our fellowship is with the Father and with his Son: Once the Spirit regenerated the apostles, they entered into spiritual fellowship with the Father and the Son. • you may have fellowship with us: Whoever entered into fellowship with the apostles by associating with them while they were alive, or

enters now by remaining in their teaching, has fellowship with the Father and the Son through them.

1 John 1:4

so that you may fully share our joy: The *joy* that the apostles have comes from their fellowship with God the Father and the Son ([1:3](#)). Readers will *share* this joy when they enter into the same fellowship.

1 John 1:5

God is light: This *light* shone through Jesus Christ to all he came in contact with, to expose their sin and to illumine the moral nature and character of God (see [John 1:4-5](#), [9](#); [3:19-21](#); [8:12](#); [9:5](#); [12:35-36](#), [46](#)). In the writings of John, "light" represents God's holiness and revelation. It is the opposite of false teaching and undisciplined living, which is "darkness" ([1 Jn 1:6](#)).

1 John 1:5-2.6

Here John focuses on the first aspect of living in fellowship with God. Living in the light means that the believers will see that they are sinners, but they will also realize that Jesus is their Advocate to make them right with God (see [Eph 5:6-13](#)).

1 John 1:6

This is the first of several instances in which John challenges the claims of the Gnostics, who had broken away from the apostolic fellowship and were thus living in spiritual darkness. They claimed to have fellowship with God but did not express his character, which is light. Jesus had warned the Jewish leaders of his day not to let the light they thought they had be darkness ([Matt 6:23](#))—their religious beliefs had blinded them to the spiritual illumination they could have received from Christ. In like manner, these Gnostic teachers thought they were enlightened but were actually darkened by their so-called illuminations. They claimed to have

spiritual experiences from God, yet they rejected fellowship with the ones who had actually seen God in the flesh, namely, John and the other apostles.

1 John 1:7

Believers have fellowship with each other and with God as they live in the light. People cannot say they commune with God and then refuse to have fellowship with God's people. This was the case with the Gnostics. The apostles of Christ had known Jesus Christ as God-in-the-flesh and were continuing to have spiritual fellowship with him ([1:3](#)).

1 John 1:8

If we claim we have no sin: This is the second false claim of the Gnostics (see [1:6](#)). They claimed that they were or could be sinless since Christ had abolished their sins once and for all—their higher knowledge would lift them above the realm of sin. But Christians do still sin when they live in their old nature (see [Rom 7:14–25](#)). The true Christian both acknowledges this sin ([1 Jn 1:9](#)) and trusts in Christ to take it away.

1 John 1:9

To maintain continual fellowship with God, we need to confess our sins to him. Forgiveness and cleansing are guaranteed because God is faithful to his promises and because he acts on the basis of his justice. Christ's death for our sins fulfills God's justice and acquits us of our guilt.

1 John 1:10

If we claim we have not sinned, we are calling God a liar: God's word emphasizes the permeating and penetrating nature of sin (see study note on 1:8).

1 John 2:1

In order to live "in the light" ([1:5–7](#)), one must confess sin ([1:9](#)) and stop sinning. John emphasizes sin in ch [1](#) in order to make believers despise their sin and avoid it. • if anyone does sin: Believers should repudiate sin, but they should not fear

confessing sins to God. • advocate (Greek *paraklētos*, "one who is called to our side" as comforter or advocate): Christ is our defense attorney, representing us before the Father in heaven (see [Rom 8:26–34](#); cp. [John 14:16](#)). • Jesus Christ, the . . . righteous: We, in contrast, are sinful. Because Christ fulfilled the law and paid sin's penalty for us, he can plead for us on the basis of justice as well as mercy. When God raised Christ from the dead, he accepted once for all Christ's plea for our acquittal (see [Rom 4:23–25](#)). "The righteousness of Christ stands on our side; for God's righteousness is, in Jesus Christ, ours" (Martin Luther).

1 John 2:2

sacrifice that atones: The Greek word *hilasmos* means "appeasement by means of sacrifice" (cp. [4:10](#)). Christ satisfied God's justice by dying in our place ([Rom 3:25](#)).

1 John 2:3–6

Obedience is one clear indication that we know Christ and belong to him. If we do not obey Christ, it is obvious that we do not belong to him or love him. • As we obey Christ and his commandments, our love for God and our knowledge of him will grow toward completeness and maturity. We will live . . . as Jesus did, in union with God and showing love for others.

1 John 2:7–11

The disciples had the old commandment (to love one another) from the very beginning, from Jesus himself ([John 13:34–35](#)) and from the Old Testament ([Lev 19:18, 33–34](#)).

1 John 2:8

Yet it is also new: Jesus' command provided the new basis for their love in his own demonstration of love to the disciples ([John 13:1–17](#)). • the darkness is disappearing and the true light is already shining: The light of the Good News expels darkness. Darkness cannot overcome it, especially where believers are living out the love that is in Christ.

1 John 2:9

a fellow believer: Literally *his brother*. The Greek word adelphos (also in [2:11](#)) is a generic term often used to refer to both male and female members of the same family.

1 John 2:9–11

Another indication of truly knowing Christ is one's treatment of other Christians. John is again pointing to those who claim to be spiritually enlightened but separate themselves from other Christians with an attitude of superiority. John defines such an attitude as hatred.

1 John 2:10

To cause others to stumble can also mean to ensnare or entrap them. The Greek word skandalon means a trap or a block in someone's path. The Gnostics, who taught falsehood about Christ, were hindering people by ensnaring them in error and darkness. • living in the light: A godly life will help, not hinder, the faith of other Christians.

1 John 2:12–14

John gives three classes of believers at various stages of spiritual maturity: God's children, the young in the faith (literally *young people*), and the mature in the faith (literally *fathers*).

1 John 2:15–17

The world is a morally evil system that is under the influence of Satan and is opposed to God and to Christ's Kingdom on this earth ([2:16](#); [3:1](#); [4:4](#); [5:19](#); [John 12:31](#); [15:18](#); [Eph 6:11–12](#); [Jas 4:4](#)). The world appeals to people's fleshly desires and thereby diverts them from God. Those who are from this world need God to redeem them from it.

1 John 2:18

Antichrist literally means "instead of Christ"; he claims for himself what belongs to Christ and poses

as a substitute for Christ (cp. [2 Thes 2:3](#) and [Rev 13:1–10](#)). • many such antichrists have appeared: They are the false teachers who deny that Jesus is the Christ, God's Son ([1 Jn 2:22–23](#)), God in the flesh ([4:2](#); [2 Jn 1:7](#)).

1 John 2:19

These people left our churches: This is John's first direct statement about the false teachers. At one point, they had been part of the church community, in fellowship with John and the other apostles. Then they left that fellowship and evidently formed a separate, exclusive community based on their false teachings about Jesus (see [4:1](#); [2 Jn 1:7](#); [3 Jn 1:9–10](#)). • they never really belonged with us: True believers would have stayed in fellowship with the apostles and remained faithful to their teachings.

1 John 2:20–23

for the Holy One has given you his Spirit: The Holy Spirit gives believers the ability to understand and recognize spiritual truth (see [Isa 61:1](#); [Acts 10:38](#); [2 Cor 1:21–22](#)). Those who have the Spirit know the truth about the Father and the Son and can detect what does not accord with the truth of the apostles' teaching.

1 John 2:22

John marks out as a liar any false teacher who denies that Jesus is the Christ, the Son of God, the unique revealer of the Father ([4:2](#)).

1 John 2:24–25

John instructs his readers to resist the lies of such antichrists and to remain faithful to the truth that he and the other apostles have proclaimed to them. If they would do this, then they would remain in fellowship with the Son and with the Father and have assurance of eternal life ([John 3:15](#), [36](#); [6:40](#), [47](#), [57](#); [17:2–3](#)).

1 John 2:28–29

To remain in fellowship with Christ means, in part, not being misled by any kind of false teaching. If

John's readers listen to the false teachers, they will not be in fellowship with Christ and will have reason to shrink back from him in shame when he returns, because of the judgment coming upon them.

1 John 3:1-3

When Christ returns, we will be like him, for we will see him as he really is. God's children bear the image of Christ and will share in his glory (see [Rom 8:18-30](#)). • Those who have this hope keep themselves pure, seeking to become more like Christ in anticipation of his glorious appearing. It is partly for this reason that God's children will not be ashamed when Christ comes ([1 Jn 2:29](#)).

1 John 3:4-10

This section discusses what it means to live a pure life ([3:3](#)). Being born into God's family demands purification; a life of sin—a continual lack of purity—is evidence that someone is not really God's child. Sin is incompatible with the new nature derived from the new birth. John wants believers to do what is right and thus demonstrate that they are joined to Christ and his righteousness. Those who are children of God do not make a practice of sinning, but this differs from the sort of "sinlessness" that the false teachers claimed (see [1:5-10](#) and corresponding study notes).

1 John 3:6

continues to live in him (Greek *menō*): This indicates "abiding" and "remaining" ([John 15:1-8](#)) in contrast to departing into falsehood. To the extent that we live in continual, dependent fellowship with Christ and in faithfulness to the apostles' teachings, we will not sin. • keeps on sinning: This verb denotes sin as an ongoing, repeated action. John was not saying that anyone who sins once does not know God (i.e., has no relationship with God). But if we persist in sin, we demonstrate a lack of relationship with God.

1 John 3:8

destroy: This does not mean "to annihilate" but "to break down" (see [Eph 2:14](#)), "to undo," or "to

render ineffective." Christ did not obliterate Satan; he came to undo the works of the devil by freeing people from sin and its awful consequences.

1 John 3:9-10

To live righteously means to live in a right relationship with God. (This is in contrast to the false teachers, who held that life in the spirit could not be contaminated by any behavior in a physical body.) This does not mean that we live perfect lives ([1:8](#)), but that we keep ourselves in a good relationship with God ([1:9](#)).

1 John 3:11-22

John now focuses on the believers' need to love one another (see [John 13:34](#)).

1 John 3:12-13

Cain had been doing what was evil: Cain was jealous that Abel received approval from God; this jealousy led to murder ([Gen 4:8](#)). Hatred is judged, just as the outward act that results from it (see [Matt 5:21-22](#)).

1 John 3:14

Having love for our brothers and sisters who are believers is tangible evidence that we have experienced rebirth in Christ and will have eternal life rather than death (i.e., condemnation; see [Rom 6:23](#); [Jas 5:20](#); [Rev 21:8](#)).

1 John 3:16-18

Christ's example shows that real love involves self-sacrifice. We do this by becoming truly concerned about the needs of others and by unselfishly giving time, effort, prayer, possessions, and even our lives to supply those needs.

1 John 3:19-22

Those who truly love ([3:16-18](#)) have confidence that God accepts them because real love is primary

evidence of real faith and of new life in Christ (see [4:7-8](#)).

1 John 3:23-24

John here gives a new criterion for discerning who has the Spirit. The Spirit is not the possession of an elite who are enlightened without their lives being changed. Instead, the Spirit comes to all believers and stimulates obedient discipleship ([Gal 5:22-23](#)).

1 John 4:1

everyone who claims to speak by the Spirit (literally *every spirit*): The teachers who left John's churches claimed to be prophets, but the true prophet is an instrument for the Holy Spirit's messages ([Acts 4:25](#); [1 Tim 4:1](#); [Rev 19:10](#)). Every speaker should be tested against what the Holy Spirit has said through the apostles ([1 Jn 4:2-3, 6](#)).

1 John 4:1-6

Those who belong to God ([4:4](#)) can distinguish spiritual truth from error, because the Spirit's presence ([3:23-24](#)) teaches them (see [2:20, 27](#); [John 14:15-26](#); [16:5-15](#)). Yet John provides concrete tests for the believers to apply so that there will be no confusion. These tests are a starting point for true teachers, not an exhaustive set; they were designed to address the false teachings that were being promoted in the churches of John's readers.

1 John 4:2

If a person claiming to be a prophet: John outlines a doctrinal test for prophets and teachers. Those who have the Spirit of God confess that Jesus Christ came in a real body. In other words, they must affirm the reality that Jesus is both fully man and fully God. Prophets and teachers who deny these basic teachings are antichrists ([2:18](#)). Certain false teachers in John's day (the Docetists) taught that Jesus Christ only seemed to have a human body but did not really have one. They thereby denied that God became flesh; see [1:1-3](#); [John 1:14](#)).

1 John 4:5

The world's viewpoint is one of systematic evil, opposed to God ([2:15-17](#)).

1 John 4:6

John tests the reality of a person's Christianity by whether they listen to and agree with the teachings of the apostles. • The Spirit of truth is the Holy Spirit ([John 14:17, 26](#); [15:26](#); [16:13-15](#)), who teaches the truth about Christ ([1 Jn 2:20, 27](#)). • False prophets have the spirit of deception, the spirit of antichrist, which leads people away from Christ (see study note on [2:22](#)). Therefore, union with the historic body of Christ and the consensus of teaching that began with the apostles is a sign of fidelity to Christ's work in the world.

1 John 4:7-21

John explains the source of a Christian's love and its outworking.

1 John 4:8

God is love, the source and embodiment of all love. This concept and the concept that "God is light" ([1:5](#)) form the foundation on which John writes this letter.

1 John 4:9-10

Jesus Christ, sent from God the Father, embodied and demonstrated God's love in his life on earth and in his sacrificial death on the cross as an atoning sacrifice.

1 John 4:11-12

Those who have received God's love cannot help but spontaneously love those who have done the same. As this love flows through us to each other, it becomes evident that we love God.

1 John 4:15

Those who believe in Christ have God living in them, and they live in God. The Father and the Son experience this fellowship ([John 10:38](#); [14:10](#); [17:21](#)). Experiencing God in this way is a special privilege for believers (see [John 14:20](#); [15:5](#); [17:21–24](#)).

1 John 4:17

our love grows more perfect: The Greek word translated *grows more perfect* does not mean flawless, but mature and complete. We mature as our relationship with God grows, and God's love makes our love complete. • Experiencing and expressing God's love and doing what it requires does not *make* us acceptable to God, but it does give us the assurance that we *have been* accepted, and our fears of the final judgment melt away.

1 John 4:18

perfect love expels all fear: As we live with Christ and grow more mature and complete in God's love, we have confidence in facing the day of judgment, which will be terrifying for those who don't know God ([Acts 24:25](#); [Rom 2:16](#)). • Based on consciousness of guilt, fear anticipates a deserved punishment, producing dread that is itself a foretaste of that punishment. Christ died to set us free from this dread ([Heb 2:14–15](#)).

1 John 4:19

God loved us first, while we were sinners, not only after we gave sin up ([Rom 8:5–11](#)). God started the process; when he loved us he enabled us to respond to him in love and to extend that love to others.

1 John 5:1–5

Those who believe that Jesus is the Christ and the Son of God have been born spiritually as children of God (see [John 20:31](#)). Such people are empowered by the Spirit of God to love him and others, and by their faith to obey God and overcome the evil temptations of the world. Through faith, they can love God and live in obedience to him.

1 John 5:6

And Jesus Christ was revealed as God's Son by his baptism in water and by shedding his blood on the cross (literally *This is he who came by water and blood*): John's contemporary, the heretic Cerinthus, taught that "the Christ" descended as a spirit on the man Jesus when he was baptized but left him before he died. The truth is that Jesus' baptism and death confirmed his identity as the Christ, the Son of God. Jesus of Nazareth was and is truly the Christ, the Son of God, from the beginning and forever.

1 John 5:7–8

three witnesses: The Spirit descended on Christ at his baptism (see [John 1:32–34](#)). The water is the water in which Christ was baptized (see [Matt 3:13–15](#); [Mark 1:9–11](#)). The blood is the blood that Christ shed at his crucifixion (see [Mark 15:37–39](#)). All three proclaim Jesus as God's Son ([1 Jn 5:6](#)). • After the phrase *three witnesses*, a few very late manuscripts add *in heaven—the Father, the Word, and the Holy Spirit, and these three are one. And we have three witnesses on earth*. The longer version was written in Latin several centuries after John to explain the three elements (water, blood, and Spirit) as symbols of the Trinity. This explanation found its way into some Latin editions of 1 John, including later copies of the Latin Vulgate. Eventually, Erasmus translated it into Greek and included it in what became the *Textus Receptus*, the "received text," which is why it was included in the King James Version. The longer version cannot be found in any Greek manuscript prior to the 1700s and was never cited by any of the early fathers of the church. For these reasons, few modern English translations recognize the longer version as part of the authentic text.

1 John 5:11–12

Whoever has the Son has life: Those who have the Son of God living in them have God's eternal life now—they enjoy the presence of God's Spirit ([2:20](#), [25](#), [27](#)), and they have the guarantee of eternity with God (see [Eph 1:13–14](#)).

1 John 5:16

Sins that lead to death are those involving apostasy (see [Matt 12:31-32](#); [Heb 6:4-6](#)). In the context of this letter, apostasy involves leaving the apostolic faith and joining a heretical, anti-Christian movement such as those denounced in John's letters.

1 John 5:17

not every sin leads to death: Those sins that do not involve ultimate apostasy can end in repentance and restoration (see [Jas 5:20](#)).

1 John 5:20

The NLT interprets the phrase the true God as referring to God, since the next phrase refers to his Son, Jesus Christ. John is also saying that Jesus Christ is the only true God (see [John 1:1, 18](#); [20:28](#); [Rom 9:5](#); [Titus 2:13](#); [2 Pet 1:1](#)). • To have fellowship with Jesus Christ is to have eternal life, because he is eternal life ([1 Jn 5:12](#); see [John 1:4](#); [3:16](#); [14:6](#); [20:31](#)).

1 John 5:21

In closing, John exhorts his flock to keep away from anything that might take God's place in your hearts (literally *keep yourselves from idols*). In the context of 1 John, the primary idol would be any false teaching that takes people away from Jesus Christ, who is at once fully man and fully God.